

BROADCAST TITLE:

WHO IS NIGERIA'S BUDGET REALLY FOR?

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OPENING — THE HOOK

Imagine you work hard every day. You pay your taxes. You send your children to a government school with no chairs. You go to a government hospital with no drugs. You struggle to buy food as prices keep rising.

Now imagine that the government collected your tax money, looked at your empty classroom and your sick child, and decided the most important thing to do with that money was pay a debt you never knew existed.

That is not imagination. That is Nigeria's 2026 budget.

This year, the Federal Government will spend **₦15.91 trillion** more than a quarter of the entire national budget on debt repayment alone. That same government will spend **₦2.56 trillion** on education and **₦2.46 trillion** on health.

Combined, education and health receive **₦5.02 trillion**.

Debt repayment receives **₦15.91 trillion**.

Nigeria will spend **3.17 times more** paying back loans than investing in the health and education of its 220 million people.

This is the story of where your money is going and where it is not.

PART 1 — THE BUDGET IN PLAIN NUMBERS

Nigeria's 2026 federal budget is **₦58.47 trillion**. That is the largest budget in the country's history.

But size alone means nothing if the money is not going to the right places.

Break it down and here is what you find:

Out of every ₦1,000 in the budget:

- ₦272 goes to paying back debt
- ₦397 goes to capital projects across all sectors
- ₦261 goes to salaries and government overhead
- ₦44 goes to education

- ₦42 goes to health
- ₦25 goes to agriculture and food security
- ₦1.40 goes to the entire digital economy

A government that spends ₦284 billion maintaining its Presidential Air Fleet but only ₦85 billion on digital economy is a government whose priorities are not aligned with its people's needs.

PART 2 — THE DEBT THAT IS EATING NIGERIA ALIVE

Nigeria's debt servicing bill has not always been this large.

In 2022 Nigeria spent ₦3.76 trillion on debt repayment. By 2024 that number had grown to ₦12.36 trillion. In 2026 it will reach **₦15.91 trillion**.

That is a **323% increase in just four years**.

To put that in human terms Nigeria's total public debt now stands at **₦159.27 trillion** as at December 2025. With a population of 220 million people, every single Nigerian every market trader, every student, every newborn baby carries a debt burden of approximately **₦724,000**.

You did not borrow that money. But you are paying for it.

Of the ₦15.91 trillion going to debt service in 2026, **63.86%** is domestic debt money borrowed locally at high interest rates. **33.69%** is foreign debt. This matters because domestic borrowing is significantly more expensive than foreign borrowing, meaning Nigeria is paying a premium to borrow from itself.

Between Q2 2024 and December 2025 alone just 18 months Nigeria added **₦25 trillion** to its total public debt. That is **₦1.39 trillion every month**. **₦46 billion every single day**.

PART 3 — WHAT NIGERIANS ARE NOT GETTING

While debt servicing grows, the sectors that affect everyday Nigerians most directly continue to receive a fraction of what they need.

Education Nigeria allocated ₦2.56 trillion to education in 2026. UNESCO recommends that countries allocate between 15% and 26% of their national budget to education. At the minimum benchmark of 15%, Nigeria should be spending **₦8.77 trillion** on education.

The actual allocation of ₦2.56 trillion is **₦6.21 trillion short** of even the minimum global standard.

Nigeria has over 20 million out-of-school children, the highest number in the world. The budget suggests this is not a priority.

Health Nigeria allocated ₦2.46 trillion to health, 4.20% of the budget. The Abuja Declaration signed by African heads of state including Nigeria commits governments to allocating at least **15%** of national budgets to health.

At 15%, Nigeria's health allocation should be **₦8.77 trillion**. The actual figure is **₦2.46 trillion** a shortfall of **₦6.31 trillion**.

This is the same country where patients buy their own gloves before surgery. Where doctors go on strike because salaries are unpaid. Where malaria, a preventable disease still kills thousands every year.

Agriculture and Food Security Nigeria allocated **₦1.47 trillion** to agriculture just 2.52% of the budget. Yet food inflation in Nigeria peaked at over 37% in 2024, meaning the cost of basic food items more than doubled in feel for ordinary Nigerians.

A government serious about food security does not allocate 2.52% of its budget to agriculture while its people cannot afford to eat.

PART 4 — A BUDGET BUILT ON ASSUMPTIONS THAT NEVER COME TRUE

There is another problem with Nigeria's 2026 budget that Nigerians deserve to know.

The government is projecting revenue of **₦33.19 trillion** in 2026. But in 8 out of the last 9 years Nigeria has failed to collect the revenue it projected.

In 2017 the government projected **₦5.08 trillion** and collected **₦2.66 trillion** missing by 47.6%. In 2020 the government projected **₦5.84 trillion** and collected **₦2.55 trillion** missing by 56.3%. In 2025 the government projected **₦36.35 trillion** but as at June 2025 had only collected **₦10.92 trillion**.

The pattern is clear. Nigeria's revenue projections are consistently optimistic. Based on historical performance, actual 2026 revenue could be as low as **₦20 trillion** meaning the real deficit could be far larger than the advertised **₦23.85 trillion**.

When revenue falls short, one of two things happens government borrows more, or government cuts spending. Either way, the people pay.

CLOSING — WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Nigeria's 2026 budget is not a development plan. It is a debt management plan dressed up as a development plan.

The numbers do not lie. A country that spends 6.2 times more on debt than on education has made a choice. A country that allocates **₦284 billion** to maintain presidential aircraft while giving **₦85 billion** to its entire digital economy has made a choice. A country that budgets **₦42** out of every **₦1,000** for the health of 220 million people has made a choice.

These are not accidents. They are priorities. And Nigerians the market trader in Onitsha, the teacher in Kano, the farmer in Benue, the mother in Lagos deserve to know what their government has chosen to prioritise.

The budget is a moral document. And this one tells you exactly where Nigeria's moral priorities lie.

Data Sources: Budget Office of the Federation, BudgIT Foundation, Debt Management Office (DMO), National Bureau of Statistics (NBS)

All figures sourced directly from official government documents and verified against BudgIT's 2026 Proposed Budget analysis.